

Gelada

Theropithecus gelada

Geladas are cousins of the more common savanna baboons, which are found throughout much of sub-Saharan Africa. Geladas were widespread in Africa 50,000 years ago, but have gradually been squeezed out by competing subspecies of savanna baboon as well as human pressure. Today, geladas survive only in their remote highland refuge. They can forage on grasses—including roots—more efficiently than other baboons, surviving almost entirely on the grass of high-altitude meadows in the mountains of Ethiopia. A garnish of bulbs, seeds, fruit, and insects supplements this diet.

Signal patches

Most baboons have colorful patches of bare skin on their rears, which help to communicate mood, dominance, and breeding condition. Geladas spend most of their time sitting down, with their rumps hidden, while foraging on grasses within reach of their long arms. Perhaps this is why they have developed

bare red patches on their chests. The male's patch mimics the female's, which mimics her own sexual skin and genitals with remarkable accuracy. This colorful area is used in both sexual and social interaction. "Social presenting"—a quick hind-end flash—among primates is a frequent peaceable signal, reducing aggression. Mimicry by males and non-estrous females helps enhance the message. Unless you are a gelada, however, it is hard to glean from a signal that a female is ready to mate.

Bachelor boys and bands

Geladas form herds several hundreds strong. Many males live in bachelor groups around the fringes of the herd until they are old enough to compete for dominance. The herd is comprised of several reproductive groups, or bands, each of which consists of an older male and his harem of females. They communicate using subtle facial signals and not-so-subtle "lip flicks" (see far right).

Geladas are also called **bleeding-heart baboons** after the **red patch on their chest**

adult males have long, thick mane



△ MOTHER AND INFANT

Born helpless, baby geladas clamber over and ride on their mothers about a month after birth. Gelada families spend much time grooming.

▷ ON TOP OF THE WORLD

Geladas feed in meadows in Ethiopia, above 5,600 ft (1,700 m). They sleep in high rocky cliffs close by.

